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BOOK REVIEW

Nicolas Ruytenbeek. *Indirect Speech Acts*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2021. ISBN 9781108673112 (ebook) 

Reviewed by Isabella Boux (RWTH Aachen University)

Since their first mention in Searle's work (Searle 1979), much research has been conducted on Indirect Speech Acts (ISAs). Yet, surprisingly and to the best of my knowledge, no book entirely dedicated to this topic has been written yet. As such, Ruytenbeek's book *Indirect Speech Acts* is a much-needed work that provides not only an overview of both classic and more recent research on the topic, but also offers several critical considerations on previous work. This book covers the topic of speech acts from a variety of angles: theoretical linguistics, empirical linguistics, as well as psycho- and neurolinguistics.

In Chapter 1, Ruytenbeek provides an overview of the classic definitions of indirectness found in the linguistic and philosophy of language tradition since the '70s (e.g., Bach & Harnish 1979; Searle 1979), including the role of indirectness as a politeness strategy (Brown & Levinson 1987). However, the author notes how these classic theories of ISAs have often been used to explain a large variety of expressions in a rather undifferentiated manner. A careful examination of these expressions, shows that they are not all equal. The author argues that indirect requests such as "Can you VP" instantiate two distinct properties. On the one hand, these ISAs are *conventionalized* (a notion reminiscent of Clark's conventionalization of means 1979), namely they can correspond to specific strategies in the use of ISAs. On the other hand, they are also *standardized* (reminiscent of Clark's conventionalization of form 1979, and Bach & Harnish's standardization 1979), namely they are carried out by means of specific syntactic forms which are tightly associated with a specific indirect meaning, so that the direct meaning might just be bypassed (see 'short-circuited' ISAs, Morgan 1978).

In Chapter 2, the author moves on to make the point that, even if the literalist view according to which the three sentence types (declarative, imperative, interrogative) correspond to specific speech acts (stating, requesting, questioning, respectively) should be rejected, some semantic properties of these three sentence types might make them particularly compatible with the performance of specific (indirect) speech act types. Interrogatives are incomplete representations of a state of affairs, which indicate the speaker's lack of knowledge about whether there might be certain obstacles to the listener performing a given action sentence (see also the 'Obstacle Hypothesis' by Fancik & Clark 1985). For instance, the question

“Would you pass the sugar?” can be used to assess whether the unwillingness of the listener can be an obstacle to passing the sugar. Incompleteness can therefore be used by the speaker to express the desire that the addressee passes the sugar, namely, to carry out indirect requests. Similarly, the affirmative sentence type can also be used to perform indirect requests (e.g., “You should close the window”) thanks to the presence of specific lexical elements such as deontic modals *should/must*, which themselves convey exhortation and/or obligation.

In Chapter 3, Ruytenbeek reviews and analyzes four cognitivist accounts of ISAs. The ‘metonymic illocutionary scenario’ account (Panther & Thornburg 1998), the ‘illocutionary force prototypicality’ account (Pérez Hernández 2013), Relevance Theory (Sperber & Wilson 1996) and the Graded Salience Hypothesis (Giora 2004), according to which all salient meanings of an utterance are processed by default, which is consistent with the evidence that standardized indirect requests are processed as fast as direct speech acts (Gibbs 1983). In sum, Ruytenbeek points to the fact that, contrary to the linguistic accounts of indirectness, these cognition-oriented accounts share a graded (rather than categorical) notion of indirectness. This suggests that utterances can be placed on a continuum between highly explicit and highly implicit, depending on the cognitive effort that is needed to access the implicit meaning. In addition, Ruytenbeek, similar to Pérez Hernández (2013), emphasizes the idea of *illocutionary force salience* as one of the factors that facilitate the processing of ISAs in addition to the previously mentioned *conventionalization* and *standardization*.

In Chapter 4, the author summarizes empirical work investigating the cognitive basis of comprehension of ISAs. First, the author articulates his review around four questions that have motivated past ISA research:

- Q1. What cognitive differences are there in understanding the same speech act being carried out in a direct or indirect manner?
- Q2. What are the processing differences between interpreting a given linguistic form directly vs. indirectly?
- Q3. Is it necessary to process the direct meaning of an ISA to access the indirect meaning?
- Q4. What properties of the stimulus make the direct interpretation more likely to be accessed?

The author does so by touching upon a variety of classic, as well as more recent, studies, ranging from behavioral experiments to eye tracking and neurolinguistic studies. This review also demonstrates how these questions have often been addressed without awareness of factors that could have affected or even confounded the results. After suggesting in Chapters 1 and 3 that the ease of processing ISAs is affected by their *conventionality*, their degree of *standardization*, and

their *illocutionary force salience*, the author turns to examining how results of past research can be related to the possible role of these three factors and to some recent literature explicitly assessing them. Finally, the last sections are devoted to some under-investigated aspects of ISAs, such as their prosody and the role of co-occurring emojis in the comprehension process.

In Chapter 5, the focus is on the sociolinguistics of indirectness: how does the social context affect the use of indirectness and what does the use of indirectness tell us about the social context? The author summarizes the main accounts about the benefits of indirectness use in communication. These include classic accounts such as the ‘plausible deniability’ account (Pinker 2008) and the already mentioned politeness account by Brown & Levinson (1987). Some other less notorious accounts are also put forward: indirectness also allows for multiple meanings, immediacy, and intimacy. The author emphasizes how all these possibilities, which might be viewed as competing accounts, are in fact compatible with one another. Next, the author focusses on the politeness account by Brown and Levinson, which predicts the effects of the degree of imposition (e.g., of a request), the social status, and the social closeness of the interlocutors, as well as a linear interaction between all these factors. The author highlights how empirical evidence supports a role of these factors but how it has also revealed complex, non-linear interactions between them, and reviews the evidence for additional less explored factors (e.g., gender, speaker personality).

In Chapter 6, Ruytenbeek reviews computational models for comprehension of indirectness as well as the use of indirectness within the context of interactions between humans and artificial agents. First, the author turns to computational models of ISAs which have typically had the aim to correctly identify indirect requests. While different models relying on fixed or adaptable sets of rules are discussed, the author points out the limitations of these models, in particular their failure at comprehending non-conventional indirect requests such as “It is cold in here” or their lack of sensitivity to different degrees of standardization of IRs. He also notes how many of them lack cognitive plausibility, which in turn does not always make them suitable tools to model human cognition. Next, the author turns to the use of indirectness in human-robot interaction. Given recent findings that suggest that humans do use indirectness when addressing requests to robots, it becomes crucial that robots comprehend them and respond to them appropriately.

ISAs are a topic that has always been at the crossroads between disciplines. A strength of this book is that it does justice to that by adopting an interdisciplinary approach, joining perspectives from philosophy of language, linguistics, and cognitive science, to a degree extending even into neurolinguistics. In this context, I believe this book to be an excellent contribution in that it provides a starting

point and establishes common ground between researchers with different backgrounds, which can facilitate interdisciplinary synergies which will be crucial for a better understanding of this linguistic phenomenon. Consequently, this work is appropriate for both students and more advanced scholars who are interested in gaining insight into this specific research topic. On the one hand, readers with a classic linguistics background will benefit from the critical review of the empirical literature to inform theory. On the other hand, people coming from the empirical field can greatly benefit from being aware of the linguistic theoretical frameworks presented here which can undoubtedly contribute to designing better studies and foster theory-driven hypotheses.

In this book, Ruytenbeek reminds us how limited consensus has, in fact, been reached in the description and understanding of this phenomenon and its cognitive basis. The realization of ISAs is indeed incredibly variable. It is therefore unsurprising that the results of empirical investigations have been quite varied as well, making it sometimes difficult to reach a satisfactory understanding of the phenomenon. In the literature, several authors have pointed to the possibility that some factors might affect the processing of ISAs (e.g., that some ISAs in the form of “Can you VP?” could be short-circuited). In past empirical research, the role of these factors has, however, typically been considered in a rather scattered fashion and has rarely been examined systematically in carefully designed experiments. In addition, conclusions from studies focusing only on specific standardized and/or conventionalized ISAs have been assumed to generalize to all ISAs. In this book, the author takes insights from previous work, re-proposes these three distinct notions of *standardization*, *conventionalization*, and *illocutionary force salience*, refines them, and puts them jointly in the foreground, hypothesizing that these might facilitate the processing of ISAs. The author also re-examines past literature while taking these factors into account. By doing so, he attempts to give a new sense to past findings. In addition, he provides an excellent impulse for future research, highlighting the need for the integration of these factors in future study designs to systematically observe their possible influence on the processing of ISAs.

Another merit of this book is that ISAs are contextualized and related to the contemporary research and societal landscape. For instance, one can appreciate how topics such as the effect of prosody and the presence of emojis on the comprehension of ISAs have also found a place in this book. This fits well with the current multi-modal turn in the language and cognitive sciences, which increasingly emphasize the role of para- and extralinguistic cues in situated communication. In addition, the sections dedicated to human-robot interaction of ISAs also highlight the relevance of investigating the phenomenon of ISAs. As interactions between humans and artificial agents become more frequent in our

lives and much effort is focused on making these interactions more natural and human-like, understanding how indirect communication can be implemented and improved in such interactions is also a key objective in our society.

The present book also highlights areas for future investigation. For instance, after reviewing a large body of available literature that mostly focuses on *conventionalized/standardized* indirect requests, the author does not fail to point out how these are only a fraction of the possible instantiations of indirectness. Ruytenbeek emphasized that much work is needed to understand how such findings generalize or extend to other types of speech acts carried out indirectly (e.g., refusals, offers, statements, etc.) or to less *standardized* and/or *conventionalized* ISAs. In addition to theoretical and behavioral research, neurolinguistic research can also be a useful venue to address some of the outstanding questions about ISA cognition and to test some of the novel hypotheses presented in the book. For instance, neurolinguistics can be a promising tool in addressing questions about the degree of processing of the direct meaning of ISA, about the temporal relation between the processing of direct and indirect meaning, as well as in testing the proposed effects of *standardization*, *conventionalization*, and *illocutionary force salience* of ISAs.

Overall, Ruytenbeek's book on "Indirect Speech Acts" provides a critical and interdisciplinary overview of theoretical and empirical research on ISAs and their cognitive basis. By doing so, he not only provides an overview for those approaching this area of research for the first time, but also reminds us all of how much we still need to understand about this linguistic phenomenon, while directing us towards new research endeavors.

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Isabella Boux is a researcher and lecturer at the RWTH University Aachen, Institute for Psychology. She has obtained her PhD in Linguistics from the Free University Berlin, Institute of German and Dutch Languages and Literatures. Her main research interest is understanding the neuro-cognitive basis of pragmatic phenomena, with a specific focus on speech acts, indirect speech acts and communication in interaction.

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